

THE AWAKENARTS PATH

Poetry, Image, and the Practice of Recognition

Language sometimes takes shape before its meaning becomes clear.



Susan Ann Shepler

When Language Takes Shape

A poem or image can sometimes hold an experience before it can be clearly named. We may recognize its meaning only later, after returning to it with time and attention.

Recognition matters because an experience can influence us before we understand it. When an image, story, or poem gives that experience a form, we can look at it more clearly. What once felt vague may become visible. What was difficult to express may begin to find language. That pause between experience and response can open room for awareness, discernment, and choice.

AwakenArts grew from this practice of returning, noticing, and recognizing. Its purpose is not to provide a fixed interpretation of an image. It is to help us attend to symbolic language: the language through which image, story, poetry, Scripture, memory, and lived experience often carry more than they can explain directly.

This path begins with attention.



Why Symbols Matter

Human beings have always used symbols. We find them in Scripture and parable, in myth and folktale, in poetry and painting, in architecture and ritual, in dreams, memory, and ordinary speech.

Water, fire, bread, gardens, trees, birds, doors, bowls, mountains, bridges, light, and paths appear again and again. Their recurrence does not mean that each image has one universal definition. It means that certain forms have carried human attention across cultures and generations.

A symbol is not an equation. Water may suggest cleansing, danger, life, grief, passage, or renewal. A garden may hold abundance, enclosure, labor, loss, or return. A bridge may suggest connection, transition, risk, or the crossing between one condition and another. Context matters. The life of the person encountering the image matters. The story in which the image appears matters.

Symbols are powerful because they can hold several dimensions of experience at once. They do not always resolve complexity; often they give it a form that can be approached.

Scripture and Symbolic Language

Christian Scripture is rich with symbolic language: light and darkness, wilderness and garden, bread and water, seed and harvest, body and vine, gate and path. Jesus often taught through parable, allowing familiar images to carry spiritual truth beyond a single explanatory statement.

AwakenArts is grounded in Christian faith. Scripture remains an authority and a source of orientation for its creator. At the same time, the practice does not claim that every personal image has a single prescribed meaning or that every reader must arrive at the same response. Faithful attention includes humility. We look closely, remain attentive to context, and resist turning mystery into a formula.

The aim is not to make Scripture subjective. Nor is it to give private symbolism the authority of Scripture. The aim is to recognize that image and story have always been among the ways human beings receive, remember, and respond to meaning.

Read My Foundation



Learning the Language of Recognition

Symbolic literacy begins not with a dictionary of meanings, but with attention.

We may sense something before we have words for it. A recurring image, a line of poetry, a remembered place, or an unexpected detail may remain with us. Recognition begins when we pause long enough to notice that it is there.

Looking begins the encounter. Recognition brings something into awareness. Making gives the response a form that can be revisited.

This is different from trying to decode an image correctly. AwakenArts does not ask, “What does this symbol always mean?” It asks questions such as:

- What draws my attention?
- What stays with me?
- Where have I encountered this image before?
- What is happening around it?
- What memories, feelings, Scriptures, stories, or questions does it awaken?
- What changes when I give my response a form?

These questions do not eliminate interpretation. They slow it down. They help us distinguish observation from assumption and allow meaning to emerge in relationship with context.

Recognition Rather Than Prescription

Recognition is personal, but it is not careless. It can be informed by Scripture, history, literature, cultural tradition, psychology, artistic form, and lived experience. These sources deepen attention; they do not reduce a symbol to a single answer.

We can hold two truths together:

- Symbols participate in shared human patterns.
- Their meaning is shaped by the particular context in which they appear.

This balance protects both breadth and integrity. It allows us to learn from recurring symbolic traditions without forcing every image into a predetermined scheme.

What Recognition Makes Possible

Recognition creates a pause between experience and response. Something that once felt vague, recurring, or difficult to express can be observed more clearly and considered from another perspective.

That pause may make possible:

- greater awareness of recurring patterns;
- language for an experience that has been difficult to name;
- a more considered response in place of an automatic one;
- deeper engagement with Scripture, literature, art, or personal memory;
- a form that can be carried into reflection, conversation, prayer, or creative work.

AwakenArts offers no diagnosis and promises no particular outcome. It offers a creative structure for noticing, expressing, and continuing with what becomes meaningful.



Seek. Find. Make.

Seek, Find, and Make describe three movements within the practice of recognition. They are not rigid steps. They may overlap, repeat, or lead back to one another.

Seek

Seek creates the pause.

Look closely before deciding what an image must mean. Attend to color, shape, placement, gesture, repetition, contrast, absence, and atmosphere. Notice what the work presents before explaining it.

Seeking is an act of patience. It allows the image to remain present long enough to be seen.

Find

Find notices what draws attention, lingers, or connects with something personally recognizable.

What detail keeps returning? What feels familiar or unexpected? What connection appears between the image and a memory, story, Scripture, question, or present circumstance?

Finding is not the discovery of a correct answer. It is the recognition of a meaningful point of contact.

Make

Make gives recognition a form.

The form may be a word, question, mark, arrangement, journal entry, prayer, poem, sketch, collage, photograph, conversation, or other creative response. Making allows what has been noticed to become visible enough to revisit.

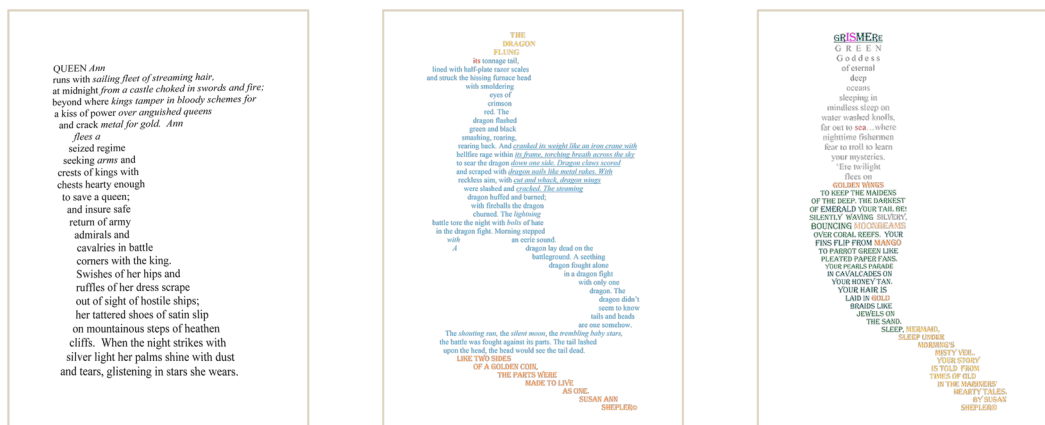
The purpose is not artistic performance. The purpose is to carry recognition forward.

Together, these movements help us travel from an unformed response toward greater awareness:

Seek what is present. Find what carries meaning. Make a form that can hold the response.

Original AwakenArts Works as Examples

AwakenArts works are not definitions of symbolic language. They are examples of how symbolic form can emerge through attention, memory, faith, and making.



Poppy

Her Mother's Hands began in grief and memory. Poppies recalled the hills near Susanville, where the artist's mother is buried. During the making, the poem's leaf shapes came to resemble two hands joined in prayer, echoing hands that sewed clothes and made quilts.

The form was not planned as an illustration of a predetermined meaning. It became recognizable through the process. Another viewer may first notice color, grief, prayer, renewal, or something

altogether different. The work demonstrates how personal memory and shared symbolic forms can meet without requiring identical interpretations.

Queen Anne

Queen Anne was written during a season of change and uncertainty. Only later did the artist recognize something of her own search for a way forward in the figure's passage from a troubled kingdom.

For the artist, Christian faith remained the grounding kingdom toward which she could turn. Another reader may notice danger, courage, exile, transition, or hope. The figure holds the threshold between what has been left and what has not yet been reached.

[*Download the Queen Ann Poem \(PDF\)*](#)

Angel Gardens

Angel Gardens began in wordplay, rhythm, and the pleasure of hearing language take shape. As the lines lengthened, they formed the suggestion of a dress, placing the figure along an axis between heaven and earth.

The work shows that symbolic form may arise through sound, visual arrangement, and play as well as through deliberate reflection. Meaning is sometimes recognized after the form has already begun to appear.

These works are offered as illustrations of process, not as complete Edition experiences. The Editions preserve the fuller relationship among image, poem, sequence, and reflection.



A Practice of Attention

Choose an image and remain with it for a few minutes before reading an explanation or searching for a definition.

Ask:

- What do I notice first?
- What stays with me?
- What is happening in the image, and what is absent?
- What associations arise from Scripture, story, art, memory, or experience?
- Which association belongs to the image's context, and which belongs to mine?

- What word, question, mark, arrangement, or image could hold my response?

There is no requirement to reach a conclusion. The practice is complete when attention has deepened and a meaningful response has been given room to take shape.



Continue the Journey

The AwakenArts Path is an introduction to symbolic literacy and the practice of recognition. It is not a collection of answers and not a substitute for the fuller works and experiences that follow.

AwakenArts is a growing body of work. Additional offerings are being developed and will be introduced as they become available.

The journey can continue in several ways:

Monthly Symbol Series

Explore one enduring symbol at a time through Scripture, literature, art, story, and reflection. Each issue considers recurring patterns while allowing context to shape meaning. Over time, the series builds a growing library of symbolic literacy and a continuing practice of attention.

Encounters

Enter a guided experience in which image, language, reflection, and Scripture unfold together. Encounters invites participation before explanation.

[Enter the Encounter Sequence](#)

Editions and Companions

Each Edition offers a complete visual-poetic encounter. Its Companion supports reflection, writing, discussion, and making. Together they provide material for personal use, guided study, and facilitated conversation.

[Experience the Poppy Edition](#)

Seek & Find Journals

Practice recognition through carefully shaped sequences of image, prompt, reflection, and response. The journals are designed for continued use rather than passive reading.

Workshops

Experience an Edition in community through image-led facilitation, poetry, conversation, writing, and take-home practice.

Prints and Cards

Live with and share symbolic imagery beyond the page. Print products extend the visual presence of AwakenArts into daily life and relationship.

AwakenArts is a way of paying attention, not a set of answers. It invites us to look closely, remain attentive to context, recognize what carries meaning, and give that recognition a form.

The path continues wherever attention becomes recognition.

